TEAM LEADER ESSENTIALS

Team Leader Essentials — Day 2: Setting Expectations and Running a Daily Huddle

Study guide · Self-study

Day 2: Setting Expectations and Running a Daily Huddle

How to Use This Guide

Today you move from doing the work yourself to making sure the whole team knows what good looks like. Day 1 covered the accountability shift and delegation. Today builds two practical tools on top of that: clear expectations and a short daily huddle that keeps everyone moving in the same direction.

Read each section once. Then stop and do the reflection lines. Write your answers before you look at the Model Answers at the end. This guide is a practice space, not a reading assignment.

You will finish the day with three things you can use tomorrow: a written expectation for one team member, a 10-minute huddle agenda, and one piece of SBI feedback written for a real person on your team.

You already do the work well. The work now is making the people around you do it well, consistently, without you standing over their shoulder.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) model and the five parts of a focused daily huddle.

Attitude: You will accept that an unclear expectation, not a lazy team member, is the most common reason performance drifts. Your job is to remove the fog, not to push harder.

Skill: You will be able to write a clear expectation with a measure of success, run a 10-minute huddle, and deliver feedback that is specific, factual and easy to act on.

Upskill: You will be able to turn a recurring blocker from your huddles into a change in how the team works, not just a problem you keep putting out.

Setting Expectations That Mean Something

Most performance problems start before the performance. A team member misses a target, a customer complaint lands, a report arrives late. When you dig in, the real problem is often that nobody ever said clearly what good looked like. The person thought they were doing fine.

An expectation has three parts. What is the task or behavior. What does good look like, in observable terms. And how will you both know it happened.

Vague: "Improve your follow-up with customers." That cannot be done or measured. The person will guess, and you will judge. Both of you end up frustrated.

Clear: "Every customer who asks a question you cannot answer gets a call or email back within one business day. Log it in the follow-up note. I will check the notes on Friday."

Now the person knows what to do, when, and how it will be checked. There is no guessing and no surprise.

Here is the psychology underneath this. People do not resist being measured. They resist being measured against a rule they only discover when they break it. When the standard is unclear, the team member fills the gap with their own assumption, and their assumption usually protects them.

That is not laziness. It is how people behave when the map is blank. Your job is to draw the map before they walk on it.

Set expectations in person when you can. Write them down in one or two lines. Then ask the person to say back what they understood. Their words, not a yes. If they can say it, they own it. If they cannot, you have not been clear enough yet.

Building Trust with Clear Measures

Clear expectations sound strict to some new leaders. In practice they build trust. When the standard is stated up front, a team member stops worrying about hidden rules and starts focusing on the work. Fairness feels visible to everyone.

Clarity also removes the conflict you would otherwise face later. A conversation about a missed standard goes very differently when the standard was agreed and visible. You are not debating what should have happened. You are looking together at what did.

One thread carries over from Day 1: delegation works only when the person knows what done looks like. Delegate the outcome and the measure, not the steps.

Reflection: Think of a time a manager judged you against a standard you had never been told. Write the feeling it created. Now think of one expectation on your team today that is still fuzzy. Write it here in plain words.

Running a Daily Huddle

A huddle is a short, standing meeting at the same time every day. Ten minutes, same order, ending on time even when it is going well. The point is alignment and action, not reports.

Here is where the psychology matters. Most team meetings die because they have no shape. People do not know when it will end, whether they will be put on the spot, or what they are supposed to say. That uncertainty makes them guard the exit. They check out before it starts. A fixed structure with a hard stop lowers the perceived cost of showing up, and attention follows.

The five parts of the huddle, in this order:

Scoreboard: one or two numbers that matter today. Keep it to a couple of minutes.

Win: one specific positive observation about someone's behavior, using SBI. One minute.

Focus: one behavior for the whole team to prioritize today. Three minutes.

Commit: each person says out loud the one action they will take today. Three minutes.

Blockers: what you, as team leader, will take on or clear. One to two minutes.

The Commit part is what turns a report into an action meeting. When a person says a specific action out loud, in front of others, they are far more likely to do it. This is commitment and consistency, described by Robert Cialdini: people feel a pull to act in line with a commitment they have made publicly. You are not forcing anything. You are asking each person to name one thing, which is easy, and the daily rhythm does the rest.

The huddle rules keep it short. Same time, same place. Stand up. Ten minutes, strictly. One focus per day, not a list of everything that is wrong. Problems go offline. If a real problem comes up, name it and say: "Let's solve that right after, you and me."

That last rule protects the huddle. When one issue takes over, everyone else stops paying attention and the meeting loses its fairness. The person raising the problem gets your full attention right after, which is better for them too.

Practice example: A team leader runs the huddle at 8:45 each morning. Scoreboard: two open service tickets and one pending quote. Win: "Mira, the way you called that customer back before the deadline yesterday kept a frustrated account steady. Thank you." Focus: today, every customer who leaves a message gets a call back the same day. Commit: each person names their one action. Blockers: one team member needs a pricing answer from another department, and the leader takes it on before 10:00. The huddle ends at 8:55.

Keep the Win real. Find something specific and true. A vague "good job everyone" teaches the team that praise is noise. A specific SBI teaches them what to repeat.

Giving Feedback with SBI

The day's feedback tool is SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact; Center for Creative Leadership). It has three parts: describe the specific Situation, the observable Behavior and its Impact, then have the person practice. Specific, factual feedback is easier to hear and act on.

Why does it work? Feedback that sounds like a judgment of character triggers defense. The person hears "you are careless" and starts building a case about their intentions. Feedback about an observable moment lands differently. There is nothing to defend because you are describing what happened, not who they are. The Impact part connects the behavior to something the person cares about: the customer, the team, the result. Then practice moves it from a comment to a skill.

An example of weak feedback: "You need to be more careful on customer calls."

The same moment with SBI: "Yesterday at 11:00 with the customer from the north branch (Situation), you gave the delivery window before checking stock (Behavior). The customer planned around a date we may not meet, and they called back upset (Impact). Let's do a quick practice run on holding the answer until you've checked."

Notice there is no "but" and no attack. You described a moment, a behavior and a consequence. That is easier to hear and hard to argue with.

On Day 3 you will go deeper into coaching conversations and questions that help people find their own answers. For today, SBI plus one practice round is enough.

Positive feedback also uses SBI. The Win in your huddle is exactly that: a specific moment, a specific behavior, a real impact. Do this daily and your team starts to see what good looks like in living color.

Apply It in Your Role

Pick the setting closest to your day.

If your team is in B2B selling: your daily scoreboard might be pipeline actions, say the number of qualified conversations booked, rather than only closed deals. Keep the focus on the behavior that drives the number.

If your team serves customers in B2C or customer service: your scoreboard might be calls answered within a target time and open complaints. Your Focus is one service behavior for the day.

If your team is a mix, choose one shared behavior that everyone can act on today.

Adjust the details to your team. The structure holds: scoreboard, win, focus, commit, blockers.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each before reading the Model Answers.

1. A team member was late to the huddle twice this week. You want to address it with SBI. Write your opening two sentences.

2. A team member says, "Honestly, the daily huddle feels like a bit of a waste of time for me." What do you say?

3. During the huddle, one team member starts a long back-and-forth with another about a problem customer. What do you say to protect the ten minutes?

Key Takeaways

An unclear expectation, not a lazy team member, is the most common cause of drift. State what good looks like, how it will be checked, and ask the person to say it back.

Clear expectations build trust because they remove hidden rules. Fairness is something people can see.

A huddle works because its structure lowers uncertainty: same time, same order, ten minutes, hard stop.

Commit is the difference between a report and an action meeting. Each person names one action out loud.

Problems go offline. Name them, then solve them right after with the people involved.

Use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) for both correcting and appreciating. Describe what happened, not who someone is.

> **NOTES**
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> Watch for the moment you slip into character judgments ("you're not really a team player"). Go back to the moment, the behavior, the impact. That is the part you can both see and fix.

Quiz

Answer all five. Write your answers, then check the notes.

1. What is the main reason to set clear expectations up front?

   A. It shows the team who is in charge.

   B. It removes the guessing that leads to drift, and builds trust because the standard is visible.

   C. It protects you if you need to dismiss someone.

   D. It saves time because you never have to give feedback.

2. Which order matches the five-part huddle?

   A. Scoreboard, Win, Focus, Commit, Blockers.

   B. Win, Scoreboard, Blockers, Focus, Commit.

   C. Scoreboard, Focus, Blockers, Win, Commit.

   D. Commit, Focus, Scoreboard, Win, Blockers.

3. Why does the Commit part change the meeting?

   A. It fills the remaining time.

   B. It lets you check up on each person.

   C. Each person names one action out loud, which makes follow-through more likely.

   D. It is the only part where you speak.

4. A team member arrived late twice this week. Which opening uses SBI best?

   A. "You're always late and it's disrespectful to the team."

   B. "On Tuesday and Thursday you arrived about four minutes after the huddle started. The team had to repeat yesterday's commit for you, and it slowed everyone down. Let's look at what's causing the timing."

   C. "Would you like to start coming on time?"

   D. "Someone has noticed you're not punctual lately."

5. What should you do when a real problem surfaces mid-huddle?

   A. Solve it completely right then so it is handled.

   B. Ignore it and hope it goes away.

   C. Name it, then say: "Let's solve that right after, you and me."

   D. Ask the team to vote on whether it matters.

Upskill Challenge

Do this over the next three working days.

Day A: Write a clear expectation for one team member using the three parts (task or behavior, what good looks like, how you will both know). Meet them for five minutes and ask them to say it back. Note what they repeated differently from what you meant.

Day B: Run one 10-minute huddle using the five parts. Stand up. End on time. Afterward, write two lines: which part ran longest, and who committed to a specific action.

Day C: Write one piece of SBI feedback, positive or corrective, for a real team member. Deliver it. Then write the Impact you saw.

At the end, answer these:

What was harder than expected?

What did your team member say back that showed your expectation was or was not clear?

Use your own real names and numbers. Do not invent team results you do not have. If you do not yet record a daily number, start with one this week.

If you do not lead a team yet: write the expectation for a task you share with a colleague and check it with your manager; run a 10-minute huddle with peers on a shared task, or ask to co-run your team's huddle; give one piece of positive SBI feedback to a peer.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Make the words sound like you. The principle matters more than the exact wording.

1. Late arrivals, SBI: "On Tuesday and Thursday this week, you joined the huddle four minutes after we started. I had to repeat yesterday's commit and one person's action got delayed. I want to understand what's happening in the morning and find a fix together." Why it works: the Situation and Behavior are observable, the Impact is real, and the ending invites a conversation rather than a verdict.

2. Huddle feels like a waste of time: "Thank you for saying it straight. Can you tell me which part feels like it isn't landing for you?" Then listen. If the huddle runs long or turns into a report, that is your job to fix: keep it to ten minutes and make Commit do the work. Say: "The goal is ten minutes and everyone leaving knowing their one action. What would make it worth ten minutes to you?" Why it works: you treat it as information, not a challenge, and you ask a what question instead of defending the meeting.

3. Problem takes over the huddle: "I can see this matters. Let's park it here and you and I will sit down right after the huddle to work it out." Then return to the next part. Why it works: you protect the group's time and give the problem real attention, so nobody loses.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. Clear, visible standards remove guessing and make fairness visible to everyone.
- 2. A. Scoreboard, Win, Focus, Commit, Blockers, in that order, every day.
- 3. C. Words said out loud in front of others create a commitment people want to keep.
- 4. B. It describes the situation and the behavior, states the impact, and invites a conversation, without judging character.
- 5. C. Problems go offline: name them, then solve them right after with the people involved.

References

- Center for Creative Leadership (CCL) — SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact).

- Cialdini, R. B. (2021). Influence, New and Expanded: The Psychology of Persuasion. Harper Business.